St. Joseph's Anglo-Chinese School
F.5 English Language
Grammar – Lesson 4: Cleft sentences

Cleft sentences

Part 1: Proofreading quiz

Your teacher has put two paragraphs on the board. One argues that technology has made people lazier (Paragraph A). The other argues that technology has not made us lazier (Paragraph B). Each paragraph contains FIVE errors. The errors include relative clauses, inverted patterns and nominalisation. Proofread the paragraphs.

Can anyone seriously deny that technology has made us lazier? Not only teenagers waste entire afternoons watching videos, but they also order every meal through delivery apps who bring food to their door within minutes. Apps, which are designed to help with homework, are frequently used for gaming instead. Students which live within walking distance still take the bus because moving feels like an unnecessary burden. The important of physical activity is something that our generation has completely forgotten. Only when someone hides their phone they can remember what life used to be like.

Has technology truly destroyed our work ethic, or are we simply judging a new generation by outdated beliefs? Many adults, which grew up without smartphones, accuse young people of laziness simply because their work happens on a screen. Never parents admit that teenagers today run online businesses and solve problems that older generations could not. What they fail to see is the significant of these new skills for the modern workplace. They also miss the possible that young people can be productive while holding a phone. In fact, technology has merely challenged the believe that hard work must always look physical.

Teacher's answers

Item	Correction
1A	Not only do teenagers waste entire afternoons watching videos... (Move 'do' before the subject — 'Not only' inverts the subject and the verb.)
2A	...delivery apps, which bring food to their door within minutes... (Use 'which' for things, not 'who' — a relative pronoun for things is needed.)
3A	Students, who live within walking distance, still take the bus... (Use 'who' for people, not 'which' — a relative pronoun for people is needed.)
4A	The importance of physical activity is something that our generation has completely forgotten. ('important' → 'importance' — a noun is needed after 'the'.)
5A	Only when someone hides their phone can they remember what life used to be like. (Move 'can' before the subject — 'Only when' inverts the subject and the verb.)
1B	Many adults, who grew up without smartphones, accuse young people of laziness. (Use 'who' for people, not 'which' — a relative pronoun for people is needed.)

2B	Never do parents admit that teenagers today run online businesses... (Move 'do' before the subject — 'Never' inverts the subject and the verb.)
3B	...the significance of these new skills for the modern workplace. ('significant' → 'significance' — a noun is needed after 'the'.)
4B	...the possibility that young people can be productive while holding a phone. ('possible' → 'possibility' — a noun is needed after 'the'.)
5B	In fact, technology has merely challenged the belief that hard work must always look physical. ('believe' → 'belief' — a noun is needed after 'the'.)

Part 2: Cleft sentences in formal writing

A cleft sentence breaks one idea into two parts so the most important information stands out. Study the patterns below.

Example 1: It-cleft – focusing on the cause

Plain:	People communicate less because they use messaging apps.
More formal:	It is messaging apps that make people communicate less.

Young people used to meet at the park after school, but now everyone sends messages from their bedrooms. A quick text is easier than a real conversation, so face-to-face friendships have become rare. It is messaging apps that make people communicate less, and this change will only grow deeper as technology advances.

Class question 1 (Easy): It-cleft – the cause

Simple sentence:	Young people forget social skills because they text too much.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the overuse of texting …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	It is the overuse of texting that makes young people forget social skills.

Class question 2 (Harder): It-cleft – the cause

Simple sentence:	Teenagers struggle to focus because notifications interrupt them constantly.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the constant interruptions …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	It is the constant interruptions from notifications that make teenagers struggle to focus.

Example 2: It-cleft – setting up a contrast

Plain:	Some people blame social media, but smartphones cause the real problem.
More formal:	While some people blame social media, it is smartphones that cause the real problem.

Every day there are news stories about the dangers of social media. While some people blame social media, it is smartphones that cause the real problem. Without a phone in their pocket, teenagers could not check their accounts every five minutes.

Class question 1 (Easy): It-cleft – the contrast

Simple sentence:	Some blame phones for tiredness, but late-night gaming is the real cause.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While some blame phones for tiredness …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	While some blame phones for tiredness, it is late-night gaming that is the real cause.

Class question 2 (Harder): It-cleft – the contrast

Simple sentence:	People say teenagers are antisocial, but they themselves avoid family dinners.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While people say teenagers are antisocial …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	While people say teenagers are antisocial, it is adults who avoid family dinners.

Example 3: Wh-cleft – presenting a recommendation

Plain:	Schools should teach students how to communicate face to face.
More formal:	What schools should do is teach students how to communicate face to face.

Many teachers complain that their students cannot hold a proper conversation. What schools should do is teach students how to communicate face to face. A single workshop on active listening would help teenagers rebuild the skills that messaging apps have quietly taken away.

Class question 1 (Easy): Wh-cleft – recommendation

Simple sentence:	Schools should teach students how to start a real conversation.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What schools should do …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	What schools should do is teach students how to start a real conversation.

Class question 2 (Harder): Wh-cleft – recommendation

Simple sentence:	Teenagers need a safe space to practise speaking in groups.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What teenagers need …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	What teenagers need is a safe space to practise speaking in groups.

Example 4: All-cleft – naming the only thing needed

Plain:	Teenagers only need one real conversation to remember the value of talking.
More formal:	All teenagers need is one real conversation to remember the value of talking.

Parents often buy expensive devices or hire tutors to help their children socially. All teenagers need is one real conversation to remember the value of talking. Once they experience the warmth of genuine human connection, the cold comfort of emojis will seem far less appealing.

Class question 1 (Easy): All-cleft

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need one supportive friend to feel understood.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	All teenagers need is one supportive friend to feel understood.

Class question 2 (Harder): All-cleft

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need to feel brave for a moment to speak to a stranger.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	All teenagers need is the bravery to speak to a stranger.

Part 3: Practice sets

Rewrite each simple sentence as a cleft sentence. The sentences are about technology and communication, so keep the register formal. Sets 1–4 are straightforward; sets 5–8 require you to change the part of speech.

Example Set 1 (It-cleft – the cause)

Simple sentence:	Teenagers send short messages because they are afraid of real conversations.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the fear of real conversations …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	It is the fear of real conversations that makes teenagers send short messages.

Example Set 2 (Wh-cleft – what is needed)

Simple sentence:	Students need to practise face-to-face communication.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What students need to do …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	What students need to do is practise face-to-face communication.

Example Set 3 (It-cleft – the contrast)

Simple sentence:	People blame social media, but modern phones are the real problem.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While people blame social media …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	While people blame social media, it is modern phones that are the real problem.

Example Set 4 (All-cleft – the only thing needed)

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need one proper conversation to understand the value of talking.

Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	All teenagers need is one proper conversation to understand the value of talking.

Example Set 5 (It-cleft – the cause, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	People feel brave when they insult others online because they are anonymous.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the anonymity …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	It is the anonymity of the internet that makes people feel brave when they insult others online.

Example Set 6 (It-cleft – the contrast, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	People think technology is convenient, but it actually destroys our patience.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While people think technology is convenient …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	While people think technology is convenient, it is the convenience of modern devices that destroys our patience.

Example Set 7 (Wh-cleft – the recommendation, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	Schools should make students aware that talking face to face is important.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What schools should do …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	What schools should do is make students aware of the importance of talking face to face.

Example Set 8 (All-cleft – the only thing needed, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need to be confident for one minute to start a real conversation.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*
Teacher's Answer:	All teenagers need is the confidence to start a real conversation.

Part 4: Writing Task

Instructions:

1. Write ONE paragraph (about 80 words) explaining the influence of artificial intelligence on students, and suggesting ONE thing schools could do to help.

→ Use **ONE cleft sentence** (It is … that … / What … is … / All … needs to do is …).

→ Use a relative clause or an inverted pattern e.g. Not only … / Never … / Rarely …

Sample answer 1 (It-cleft) Artificial intelligence is changing the way students learn, but not every change is positive. It is the loss of independent thinking that worries teachers most, as too many teenagers

now let apps write their essays without even reading the questions first. Schools should therefore limit AI use in all homework tasks, which would force students to develop their own ideas and opinions. A simple rule requiring a first draft without AI would restore the value of real effort.

Sample answer 2 (Wh-cleft) What concerns parents most is that their children are losing the ability to think for themselves. Artificial intelligence can answer almost any question instantly, so students no longer wrestle with difficult problems on their own. Schools should require students to complete at least one draft without any AI assistance of any kind, which would teach them the patience that genuine learning demands. Only then will they understand that struggle is not failure but the beginning of real growth.

Sample answer 3 (All-cleft) All schools need to do is teach students how to use AI as a tool rather than a replacement for thinking. Many teenagers now trust an app more than their own judgment, which means they never develop the confidence to solve problems alone. A short practical lesson on verifying AI answers with real sources would show students that true intelligence is not about speed but about understanding. This small change could transform the way they approach every subject.

Each sample uses ONE cleft: Sample 1 an it-cleft (It is … that …), Sample 2 a wh-cleft (What … is …) and Sample 3 an all-cleft (All … need to do is …). Each sample also contains at least ONE relative clause or inverted pattern — point these out to students before they write.